



FULL-BLEED HERO PHOTOGRAPH
RECOMMENDED: AVON RIVER / PORT HILLS

— YOUR JOURNEY BEGINS HERE

Christchurch Relocation Guide

WRITTEN BY ETHICARE RESOURCING · ŌTAUTAHU



Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Aotearoa.

Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Christchurch — Ōtautahi, the largest city in the South Island.

Rebuilt with energy and imagination after the 2010–11 earthquakes, Christchurch is a modern, spacious garden city — affordable, flat and easy to live in, with the mountains and the sea both within an hour. It is the gateway to the South Island.

This guide covers housing, transport, healthcare, finances and where to explore on your days off.



Lifestyle / welcome photograph

RECOMMENDED: CHRISTCHURCH WATERFRONT OR FAMILY

Nau mai, haere mai ki Aotearoa! (Welcome to New Zealand!)

Ngā mihi nui,
The Ethicare Team

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QUICK FACTS

LOCATION

Central east, South Island

CLIMATE

Temperate – four seasons

DRIVE TO QUEENSTOWN

~6 hours

MAIN CITY

Christchurch (~410,000)

MAIN HOSPITAL

Christchurch Hospital (tertiary)

NEARBY

Banks Peninsula, Southern Alps

The South Island's largest city

Christchurch is New Zealand's third-largest city and the hub of the South Island. Rebuilt after the earthquakes, it now offers a fresh, spacious, affordable city with a striking new centre and the outdoors on every side.

410K

CITY RESIDENTS

3rd

LARGEST CITY IN NEW ZEALAND

1^{HR}

TO BOTH THE MOUNTAINS AND THE
SEA

Why many professionals enjoy Christchurch

- More affordable and spacious than Auckland or Wellington
- A major tertiary hospital and medical school
- Flat and bike-friendly – easy to get around
- Gateway to the Southern Alps and the South Island

A city reborn

The 2010–11 earthquakes reshaped Christchurch, and the recovery has given it one of the most interesting urban renewals anywhere – new architecture, street art and a creative, resilient spirit.

The rebuilt centre blends heritage with bold new buildings, the Riverside Market, and the transitional 'Cardboard Cathedral'.

Ōtautahi has deep Ngāi Tahu roots, and the city's famous gardens and the Avon River give it its enduring 'Garden City' character.



Cultural moment

RECOMMENDED: CHRISTCHURCH LANDMARK

“

Christchurch wears its recovery with pride – a garden city rebuilt with creativity and resolve.

ON LIFE IN CHRISTCHURCH

Getting around

Here is how people get around Christchurch day to day – and what to know about driving in New Zealand.

DRIVING

Flat and well laid-out, with easy driving and parking; motorways link the wider region.

BUSES

The Metro bus network serves the city; flat terrain makes cycling popular.

AIR

Christchurch Airport is the South Island's main hub, with domestic and international flights.

CYCLING

Extensive flat cycleways make Christchurch one of NZ's most bike-friendly cities.

On the road

- New Zealanders drive on the left
- You can usually drive on a valid overseas licence for up to 12 months before converting to a NZ one
- A local transport card makes buses and trains easy
- Keep your overseas licence and any translation handy when you first arrive

A year in the local climate

Christchurch has a temperate climate with four distinct seasons — warm dry summers, crisp frosty winters, and the occasional warm nor'west wind off the alps.

Summer

DEC – FEB

20–24°

AVG DAYTIME

Autumn

MAR – MAY

14–20°

AVG DAYTIME

Winter

JUN – AUG

7–12°

AVG DAYTIME

Spring

SEP – NOV

13–18°

AVG DAYTIME



Seasonal / scenic photograph

RECOMMENDED: PORT HILLS / BANKS PENINSULA

Summers are warm and settled; winters bring frosty mornings and clear days, with snow on the nearby hills. Bring warm layers for winter and sun protection for summer.

Healthcare in Christchurch

Christchurch has the South Island's most comprehensive healthcare network, anchored by Christchurch Hospital – the island's largest tertiary and major trauma centre.

Christchurch Hospital

The South Island's largest tertiary hospital and major trauma centre, with the island's busiest emergency department and full specialist services.

Burwood Hospital

Specialises in rehabilitation, orthopaedics and older persons' health.

Hillmorton Hospital

The region's main centre for mental health and addiction services.

Private & ACC

St George's and other private hospitals offer elective care; ACC covers accidents for everyone.

Public & private

- Public healthcare is funded through general taxation
- ACC provides no-fault accident cover for everyone
- Private hospitals offer elective procedures and shorter waits
- Many residents hold private health insurance alongside the public system

GPs, pharmacies & urgent care

Registering with a GP and dentist

After you settle in, enrol with a local GP (General Practitioner). Enrolment means subsidised visits — typically around NZ\$50–\$70 when enrolled, more if you are a casual patient. Many practices allow online enrolment once you have an address. Dental care is private; expect roughly NZ\$90–\$150 for a check-up.

Pharmacies

Pharmacies are found throughout the region. Prescriptions are partly subsidised once you are enrolled with a GP — commonly a small standard charge per item.

Emergency & after-hours

- **Emergency Departments** — for urgent or critical care; in an emergency, dial 111
- **Urgent care clinics** — accident & medical clinics offer extended-hours care
- **Healthline 0800 611 116** — free 24/7 advice from registered nurses

Setting up your finances

Getting your finances in order early makes day-to-day life much easier. Most of this can be started before you arrive.

Opening a bank account

The major banks are ANZ, ASB, BNZ, Kiwibank and Westpac. You will usually need your passport, work or resident visa, and proof of a NZ address. Many banks let you start online before arrival, then activate in person. Ask for online banking and a debit card at the same time.

Tax (IRD number)

Every worker needs an IRD number from Inland Revenue. Apply online once you have a NZ address and bank account; processing usually takes around 7–10 working days. Give the number to your payroll team as soon as it arrives so the correct tax is applied. Wages are commonly paid fortnightly.

● Tip

Start your bank account application before you fly — having an account number ready makes your IRD application and payroll setup much smoother.

KiwiSaver & sending money home

KiwiSaver is a government-supported retirement savings scheme. On a work visa you can usually opt in or out. Contributions are a percentage of your pay (commonly 3%, 4%, 6%, 8% or 10%), with employers contributing at least 3%. You can withdraw your funds if you permanently leave New Zealand.

Sending money overseas: banks can transfer internationally, but specialist services such as Wise or OFX are often cheaper and faster. Always compare the exchange rate and the fees before moving larger amounts.

SET UP	WHY IT MATTERS	WHEN
Bank account	Receive salary, pay bills locally	Before / on arrival
IRD number	Be taxed correctly	First weeks
KiwiSaver	Retirement savings + employer top-up	When you start work
ACC	No-fault accident cover	Automatic

What life costs in Christchurch

Christchurch offers big-city services at noticeably lower housing costs than Auckland or Wellington – a major part of its appeal for families and professionals.

\$560/wk

3-BED HOUSE (APPROX. MEDIAN)

\$2.80/L

APPROX. PETROL PRICE

Left

SIDE OF THE ROAD

EVERYDAY ITEM	APPROX. PRICE (NZ\$)
1 litre of milk	\$2.50 – \$3.50
Loaf of bread	\$2.50 – \$4.00
Dozen eggs	\$7 – \$10
Flat white coffee	\$5.50 – \$6.50
Mid-range meal for one	\$25 – \$40
Monthly gym membership	\$60 – \$100
Home broadband	\$75 – \$100 / month

Prices are indicative and change over time – use the calculators at the back of this guide for a personalised estimate.

An example monthly budget

A rough single-person monthly budget for a Christchurch renter. Yours will vary with lifestyle, household size and suburb.

CATEGORY	APPROX. MONTHLY (NZ\$)
Rent (room / small 1-bed)	\$1,300 – \$2,100
Power & water	\$160 – \$240
Internet	\$75 – \$100
Public transport / fuel	\$150 – \$270
Groceries	\$450 – \$650
Mobile phone	\$30 – \$50
Entertainment	\$180 – \$360
Estimated total	\$2,400 – \$3,800

Make it personal

- Use Numbeo to compare Christchurch with your current city
- Map your own incomings and outgoings with the Sorted budget planner (sorted.org.nz)

A note from Sophie

A personal word from our Founder on what makes Christchurch special — and who it tends to suit.



● SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

Christchurch surprises people. The rebuild has given it a fresh, modern feel, and you get genuine city scale — a major hospital, an international airport — at prices that make life comfortable.

With the mountains an hour one way and the beach the other, it's a brilliant base for an outdoor life. It's one of our most popular South Island placements for good reason.

Sophie Careem · Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing

● From the Ethicare team

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with every step of your move to Christchurch — from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Finding a place to live

Christchurch offers space and value – from rebuilt central apartments to leafy suburbs and lifestyle blocks, most within an easy, flat commute.



Housing / suburb photograph

RECOMMENDED: SUBURBAN STREET OR APARTMENTS

Useful property websites

- trademe.co.nz/property – NZ's largest rental marketplace
- realestate.co.nz – nationwide rentals and homes for sale

A guide to the areas

An orientation to the main areas of Christchurch — each with its own character, price point and who it tends to suit.

Central city & Riverside

Rebuilt apartments and townhouses near the new centre, market and Avon River.

Merivale & Fendalton

Established, leafy suburbs with good schools and character homes.

Riccarton & Addington

Central, well-connected suburbs handy to the hospital and university.

Sumner & the Port Hills

Seaside and hillside suburbs with beaches and walking trails.

Across the wider region

Central city & Riverside

Rebuilt apartments near the new centre and Avon River.

Merivale & Fendalton

Established leafy suburbs with good schools.

Riccarton & Addington

Central, well-connected suburbs near the hospital and university.

Sumner & the Port Hills

Seaside and hillside suburbs with beaches and trails.

A tip on choosing

- Think about your commute to work and school zones if you have children
- Where you live can decide which state school your children attend – check the zone before you sign
- Many people rent for a few months first to get to know the areas

Utilities, rates & rubbish

POWER & GAS

Choose from providers like Genesis, Mercury, Meridian and Contact. Compare rates on Powerswitch (powerswitch.org.nz).

WATER & RATES

Council rates fund local services; if you rent, rates are usually included in your rent.

RUBBISH & RECYCLING

Kerbside collection is run by the local council, with separate bins for rubbish, recycling and food scraps.

INTERNET

Most homes have fibre broadband; Spark, One NZ and 2degrees are the main providers.

Set-up quick links

Compare power

powerswitch.org.nz

Post & parcels

nzpost.co.nz

Tenancy advice

tenancy.govt.nz

Where to shop

Christchurch offers malls, town centres and weekend markets. A few of the main ones:

Westfield Riccarton

The South Island's largest mall.

The Crossing & Re:START (CBD)

Rebuilt central-city retail and laneways.

The Tannery (Woolston)

A boutique heritage shopping arcade.

Markets

The Riverside Market and Christchurch Farmers' Market at Riccarton House.

Supermarkets & groceries

New Zealand's supermarkets fall into a few main groups. Knowing the difference helps you balance budget and convenience.

Pak'nSave

The cheapest of the big chains — a no-frills, bulk-buy warehouse format. Best for budget shopping.

Woolworths

Mid-range and widespread, with strong online shopping and delivery (formerly Countdown).

New World

More upmarket, with a wider fresh and specialty range.

Four Square & FreshChoice

Smaller neighbourhood stores for convenience and top-ups.

Christchurch has Pak'nSave, Woolworths and New World across the city, plus Costco at Northwood. Bring your own bags — single-use plastic bags are banned.

Specialty & international food

One of the joys of settling into Christchurch is finding the flavours of home — or exploring new ones.

Halal & South Asian

Halal butchers and Indian grocers serve the city, especially around Riccarton; many supermarket lines are halal-certified.

Asian groceries

Riccarton is the hub for Asian supermarkets and restaurants, with more across the city.

World food

A diverse, rebuilt food scene spanning the Riverside Market and laneway eateries.

Smaller independent stores open and close over time — a quick search for "halal butcher near me" or your home cuisine will surface the current options near your suburb.

Places of worship

Christchurch reflects New Zealand's spiritual diversity, with welcoming communities across many faiths.

Christchurch has churches of many denominations, mosques, Hindu and Sikh temples, and Buddhist and Jewish communities.

Finding your community

- Most faith communities list service times and locations online
- Many warmly welcome newcomers and visitors
- They can be one of the quickest ways to build a support network when you arrive

Mountains one way, sea the other

Christchurch is a launchpad for the South Island – ski fields and alpine lakes inland, surf beaches and Banks Peninsula on the coast, all within easy reach.



Recreation hero photograph

RECOMMENDED: PORT HILLS / BANKS PENINSULA

Don't-miss experiences

- Punt on the Avon through the Botanic Gardens
- Walk or bike the Port Hills for harbour views
- Drive to Akaroa on Banks Peninsula
- Ski the Canterbury fields in winter

Ten things not to miss

A starter list to get to know Christchurch and the wider region.

- 1 Punt on the Avon**
Glide through the Botanic Gardens by punt.
- 2 Botanic Gardens & Hagley Park**
The green heart of the Garden City.
- 3 Port Hills**
Walk or bike for harbour and city views.
- 4 Akaroa**
A French-flavoured harbour village on Banks Peninsula.
- 5 Christchurch Gondola**
Ride up for panoramic views.
- 6 Riverside Market**
A buzzing covered food and produce market.
- 7 International Antarctic Centre**
Experience the ice near the airport.
- 8 Sumner & Taylors Mistake**
Seaside suburbs and surf beaches.
- 9 Canterbury ski fields**
Mount Hutt and club fields in winter.
- 10 Quake City & Cardboard Cathedral**
The city's earthquake story and recovery.

Travel from Christchurch

Christchurch is a great base for exploring. Some favourite weekend escapes:

Akaroa & Banks Peninsula (~1.5 hrs)

Harbour village, dolphins and bays.

Hanmer Springs (~2 hrs)

Alpine thermal pools and forest.

Lake Tekapo & Aoraki (~3 hrs)

Turquoise lakes and the Southern Alps.

Kaikōura (~2.5 hrs)

Whale watching and crayfish on the coast.

Flying onward

- Domestic flights reach the main centres in around 1–2 hours
- Book early for the best fares on Air New Zealand and Jetstar
- Many regions are also linked by scenic road and rail journeys

Schooling & study

Christchurch offers a full range of early childhood education, schools and tertiary study.

Early Childhood Education (ECE)

Kindergartens, daycare, Montessori, kōhanga reo and home-based care for ages 0–5. Government 20-hours funding applies for ages 3–5.

Primary & intermediate

State, state-integrated and private schools for Years 1–8.

Secondary

Years 9–13, working towards NCEA, the national qualification.

Tertiary

Universities and institutes of technology across the country.

School terms run late January to mid-December, in four terms with two-week breaks in April, July and October.

School zones come first

In New Zealand, where you live usually determines which state school your children can attend. For many families, the school decision leads the choice of where to rent or buy.

In-zone = guaranteed

Children living inside a school's enrolment zone are guaranteed a place at that school.

Out-of-zone = ballot

If you live outside the zone you can still apply, but places aren't guaranteed – popular schools run a ballot for limited spots.

Zones are street-by-street

Boundaries can run down the middle of a street, so check the exact address.

● **The order that works best**

1) Shortlist schools you like → 2) Check each school's zone map → 3) Search for rentals inside that zone → 4) Confirm the address is in-zone before you sign.

Childcare for working families

Early childhood (0–5). Daycare, kindergartens, Montessori and home-based care are widely available. The government's 20 Hours ECE funding subsidises care for ages 3–5 at participating centres.

Before & after school (OSCAR). Many schools and providers run breakfast clubs, after-school care and holiday programmes. Subsidies may be available through Work and Income for eligible families.

TYPE OF CARE	APPROX. COST (NZ\$)
Full-time daycare (under 3)	\$350 – \$450 / week before subsidies
20 Hours ECE (ages 3–5)	Up to 20 hrs/week subsidised; extra hours charged
After-school care (OSCAR)	\$5 – \$15 per afternoon, varies by provider
School holiday programme	\$40 – \$60 per day, activity-based

Costs are indicative and vary by provider and suburb. If you'll work shifts, ask providers about flexible hours.

Christchurch for families

Beyond school and work, Christchurch is an easy, outdoorsy place to raise a family.

FREE & OUTDOORS

Hagley Park, the Botanic Gardens and beaches – much of the best fun is free.

RAINY-DAY OPTIONS

Canterbury Museum, the Antarctic Centre and Orana Wildlife Park.

LIBRARIES & PLUNKET

Tūranga and local libraries run children's programmes; Plunket supports young families.

GETTING AROUND

Flat and bike-friendly – one of NZ's easiest cities for families.

Settling kids in

- Children often settle fastest through school, sport and weekend activities
- Local clubs – football, netball, rugby, swimming – are inexpensive and welcoming
- They're a great way for the whole family to meet people

Pre-departure checklist

Work through these before you fly. Keep digital and printed copies of everything important.

Documents

- ☐ Passport + valid NZ visa (printed too)
- ☐ Job offer & employment contract
- ☐ Qualifications & certificates
- ☐ References & employment history

Money & travel

- ☐ Apply online for a NZ bank account
- ☐ Documents ready for your IRD number
- ☐ Confirm airline baggage allowance
- ☐ Book temporary accommodation

Your first weeks

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Move into your accommodation | ☐ Open / activate your bank account |
| ☐ Apply for your IRD number | ☐ Get a NZ SIM card |
| ☐ Register with a local GP | ☐ Set up power, water and internet |
| ☐ Learn your transport routes to work | ☐ Save 111 and Healthline in your phone |
| ☐ Find your nearest pharmacy & supermarket | ☐ Explore your local neighbourhood |

● You're not alone

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with any of these steps – from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Key numbers & contacts

In any emergency – police, fire or ambulance – dial **111**.

Emergency & health

Emergency	111
Healthline	0800 611 116
Mental health	Call/text 1737
Police (non-urgent)	105

Everyday services

Tax (IRD)	ird.govt.nz
Immigration	immigration.govt.nz
AA roadside	0800 500 222
Local council	govt.nz/organisations

Banks

ANZ	anz.co.nz
ASB	asb.co.nz
BNZ	bnz.co.nz
Kiwibank	kiwibank.co.nz
Westpac	westpac.co.nz

Community & expat groups

One of the quickest ways to settle in is to find your people. Christchurch has active communities for almost every interest and background.

Facebook groups

Search for groups like "Expats in Christchurch", your home-country community, and local suburb buy/sell and parents' groups.

Meetup & interest groups

Meetup.com lists hiking, sport, hobby and newcomer groups — a relaxed way to meet people.

Sports & cultural clubs

Local football, netball, rugby and cricket clubs, plus cultural and faith communities, all welcome newcomers.

Workplace networks

Many hospitals and employers have social clubs and buddy systems for new and international staff.

Rainbow / LGBTQ+ community

- New Zealand is welcoming and progressive — marriage equality has been law since 2013
- There are strong legal protections against discrimination
- OutLine Aotearoa offers rainbow mental-health support (0800 688 5463)

Everyday Māori & Kiwi phrases

Te reo Māori is part of everyday life, and Kiwis have their own slang too.

Te reo Māori

Kia ora Hello / thanks

Nau mai, haere mai Welcome

Whānau Family

Hauora Health & wellbeing

Manaakitanga Hospitality, kindness

Mōrena Good morning

Ka kite anō See you later

Tamariki Children

Ngā mihi nui Many thanks

Aotearoa New Zealand

Kiwi slang

Sweet as Great / no worries

Keen Up for it

Dairy Corner shop

Jandals Flip-flops

Flatting Shared renting

Chur Cheers / thanks

Heaps Lots

Togs Swimwear

Shout Your turn to pay

Knackered Tired

Work out your cost of living.

Use these tools to estimate what life in Christchurch would really cost for you and your family.

Cost-of-living calculators

Compare cities (Numbeo)	numbeo.com/cost-of-living
Budget planner (Sorted)	sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner
Living-costs data (Stats NZ)	stats.govt.nz
Take-home pay (IRD)	ird.govt.nz

We hope you've found this guide useful. Moving to the other side of the world is a big step, and there's a lot to take in – so please don't feel you have to have it all figured out at once.

Whatever stage you're at, we're always happy to talk anything through – the big decisions or the small worries. Just reach out to your Ethicare contact whenever you need us.

Ngā mihi nui

The Ethicare team



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